TikTok at the Crossroads: Globalization, Nationalism, and the Fragility of Digital Identity

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Abstract: This paper explores TikTok as a site where globalization and nationalism intersect. As a global mediascape, TikTok facilitates the rapid circulation of cultural forms across borders, enabling hybrid creativity and sustaining new forms of digital labor. Its content-graph algorithm, unlike Instagram's reliance on social networks, elevates unfamiliar voices and provides opportunities for monetization. Yet these same features have made TikTok a focus of nationalist anxieties. States frame the platform as a danger to sovereignty, citing risks of data collection, algorithmic manipulation, and loss of information control. India's 2020 ban and the United States' temporary shutdown in 2025 illustrate how global flows fracture under national security logics. The discussion of TikTok refugees—creators displaced by bans or exclusion—demonstrates the precarity of digital identity and livelihood. The paper argues that short-video platforms are neither simply globalizing forces nor nationalist tools, but contested terrains where cosmopolitan belonging remains fragile. Tiktokl Platform

Keywords: TikTok; Platform Nationalism; Globalization; Digital Identity; Digital Precarity

1. Introduction

Short-video platforms have rapidly become central arenas of digital culture. TikTok, the global-facing product of ByteDance, has expanded into more than 150 markets, while its sister app Douyin dominates the Chinese domestic landscape. Their shared technical architecture but divergent political contexts highlight a key paradox: digital platforms simultaneously enable global cultural flows and reinforce national boundaries. This tension makes short-video platforms an important site to study how globalization and nationalism intersect in everyday digital practices.

On one level, TikTok exemplifies globalization. Its recommendation system and participatory culture allow memes, sounds, and trends to cross borders at unprecedented speed, fostering what Appadurai terms global "mediascapes" [1]. At the same time, platforms are deeply shaped by local regulations and ideologies. In the case of Douyin, the platform is tightly integrated into China's regulatory environment, where algorithmic design and content governance align with state priorities. Nationalistic content is often amplified, and foreign influencers gain visibility primarily when they endorse Chinese cultural values [2][3].

The article proceeds as follows: the next section reviews literature on globalization, nationalism, and platform governance; the main body analyzes the globalization–localization tension and examines TikTok refugees as a case study; the discussion reflects on implications for digital nationalism; and the conclusion summarizes contributions and future directions.

2. Literature Review: Nationalism and Globalization on Short-Video Platforms

2.1. Globalization and Cultural Flows

Theorists of globalization provide a foundation for understanding how digital platforms mediate cross-border cultural exchange. Appadurai's framework of scapes conceptualizes globalization as overlapping flows of media, ideas, and people that rarely follow linear or uniform paths [1]. Similarly, Tomlinson argues that globalization is best understood as cultural interconnectivity rather than homogenization [4]. Short-video platforms like TikTok exemplify this dynamic: global trends such as dances, memes, and hashtags are continuously adapted and remixed by diverse local users.

Empirical research on TikTok confirms these processes. Zulli and Zulli describe how "imitation publics" form around meme formats that travel across languages and regions, producing hybrid cultural expressions [5]. This hybridity aligns with Appadurai's view that globalization generates new, unexpected cultural forms rather than dissolving difference.

At the same time, scholars caution against celebrating TikTok as a pure cosmopolitan arena. Lobato and Meese show that global platforms often privilege dominant languages, genres, and creators, shaping cultural flows unevenly [6]. In my view, this demonstrates that globalization on TikTok is not a level playing field: algorithmic infrastructures filter which cultural symbols gain traction, embedding power asymmetries within seemingly free flows.

2.2. Mediated and Banal Nationalism

If globalization fosters hybridity, nationalism reasserts cultural boundaries. Billig's concept of banal nationalism highlights how everyday media reproduce national identity through routine symbols—flags, metaphors, or songs [7]. Extending this to the digital sphere, scholars argue that nationalism is not weakened by digital media but transformed: platforms subtly encode national belonging into online communication [8].

Recent empirical work on Douyin demonstrates this logic. Fung analyzes how Douyin narratives contribute to "national cohesion," with patriotic content amplified as part of the platform's role as a citizens' space for unity [2]. Likewise, Zhang finds that foreign influencers on Douyin gain visibility primarily when they endorse Chinese culture, thereby embedding cosmopolitan figures within nationalist frameworks [3]. These cases illustrate how banal nationalism manifests through algorithms and platform policies, making the nation an ordinary presence in everyday scrolling.

From my perspective, this suggests that nationalism in the digital era is infrastructural as much as discursive. It is not only about explicit patriotic videos but about the coded preferences and content governance systems that privilege certain narratives of belonging.

Building on these insights, the concept of platform nationalism emphasizes how digital infrastructures reinforce national boundaries. Mihelj describes platforms as new "national public spheres" where technical architectures and regulatory regimes reproduce nationhood [8]. Lin sharpens this distinction by contrasting algorithmic cosmopolitanism—the idea that recommendation systems connect diverse users across borders—with platform nationalism, where platform design and governance embed state priorities [9].

TikTok and Douyin exemplify this paradox. TikTok markets itself as global and cosmopolitan but faces regulatory constraints in countries like India and the United States [10][19][20]. Douyin, in contrast, is explicitly nationalized, operating under Chinese laws and promoting state-aligned narratives. In my interpretation, this bifurcation demonstrates that digital borders are not metaphors but technical realities. By segmenting global and national apps, ByteDance materializes platform nationalism at the infrastructural level.

2.3. Identity Negotiation and Cross-Cultural Performance

The question then becomes: how do users navigate these tensions? Identity negotiation theory suggests that in intercultural communication, individuals balance needs for inclusion, distinctiveness, and cultural pride [11]. On TikTok, creators often enact hybrid identities by combining global memes with local references, mixing languages, or showcasing transcultural lifestyles.

By contrast, studies of foreign influencers on Douyin highlight more constrained negotiations. Sullivan shows that foreign wanghong (internet celebrities) in China achieve visibility by aligning with Chinese nationalist values and downplaying cosmopolitan critiques [12]. Zhang similarly finds that transnational influencers must adjust stigmatized identities to fit within nationalist discourses to maintain visibility [3].

This asymmetry suggests that while TikTok fosters more fluid hybridity, Douyin channels identity performances into nationalist frameworks. My view is that this reflects platform nationalism in practice: Douyin rewards assimilation into national pride, whereas TikTok tolerates greater ambiguity, though still shaped by its own algorithmic filters.

Understanding these negotiations requires attention to algorithmic governance. Gillespie conceptualizes platforms as "custodians of the internet," gatekeeping which voices become visible [13]. Bucher adds that algorithms create affective relationships: users adapt their behavior to please opaque systems of visibility [14].

On Douyin, research indicates that pro-nationalist content is disproportionately boosted, while dissenting voices are suppressed [2][3]. On TikTok, marginalized communities often perceive "shadowbanning," feeling their content is rendered invisible without explanation. Nieborg and Poell describe this as "platformization," where cultural production is increasingly dependent on opaque, profit-driven infrastructures [15].

In my interpretation, algorithms should not be seen as neutral filters. They are political actors that shape identity negotiations, amplifying national pride on Douyin and fragmenting cosmopolitan communities on TikTok.

2.4. Platform Migration and Digital Refugees

The fragility of algorithmic belonging is evident in platform migration. Kumar analyzes India's 2020 TikTok ban, showing how creators rebuilt communities on Instagram and YouTube, experiencing a form of digital displacement [10]. Media coverage and subsequent scholarship have described these users as "TikTok refugees," underscoring the emotional and economic costs of losing a digital home.

Nieborg and Poell's critique of platform dependency helps frame this: when creators' livelihoods depend on algorithms, exclusion or bans resemble exile from a nation-state [15]. In my view, the refugee metaphor captures the political stakes of platform nationalism. Users are not only consumers but digital citizens whose membership can be revoked at any time.

If TikTok refugees illustrate global fragmentation, foreign influencers on Douyin illustrate nationalist co-optation. Sullivan documents how foreigners cultivate fame by demonstrating loyalty to Chinese culture and politics [12]. Zhang extends this, showing that transnational influencers navigate a constant tension between cosmopolitan visibility and nationalist assimilation [3].

These findings echo Fung's conclusion that Douyin operates as a citizens' platform for unity [2]. From my perspective, this shows how globalization and nationalism intersect: cosmopolitan figures are welcomed but reframed, becoming vehicles for national discourse rather than alternative perspectives.

Finally, the broader context of digital sovereignty highlights how nationalism is embedded in infrastructure. Girard argues that national identity constrains even powerful global platforms, as

consumer citizenship is structured by state logics [16]. Legal scholarship on TikTok has likewise emphasized how concerns over data sovereignty fragment the global internet [17].

This literature reminds us that nationalism on platforms is not only cultural or algorithmic but geopolitical. In my view, studying TikTok and Douyin requires integrating cultural analysis with attention to regulatory regimes and global governance, since platform nationalism is inseparable from state power.

Taken together, the literature suggests three key insights. First, globalization on short-video platforms fosters hybridity but under unequal conditions. Second, nationalism is embedded not only in explicit discourse but also in platform infrastructures. Third, identity negotiations are asymmetrical: TikTok tolerates cosmopolitan hybridity, while Douyin rewards assimilation into nationalist pride.

3. Tik Tok as a battle field: between Nationalism and Globalization

3.1. TikTok as a Global Platform

TikTok's rapid rise illustrates how digital platforms create what Appadurai calls mediascapes—flows of images, narratives, and cultural symbols that cut across territorial boundaries [1]. Unlike earlier social media, TikTok is not built on a social graph but on a content graph: its recommendation system privileges creative formats over personal connections. This distinction explains why TikTok, more than Instagram or Facebook, fosters transnational cultural participation. A meme, song, or dance can go viral simultaneously in Lagos, Los Angeles, and Lahore, whereas Instagram trends typically remain limited to friend networks or regional clusters.

The result is a new form of cosmopolitan connectivity. Tomlinson reminds us that globalization is not cultural homogenization but interconnection and hybridity [4]. TikTok embodies this hybridity as users remix formats with local adaptations: a sound originating in Korea may be paired with humorous captions in the United States and reinterpreted with local slang in Nigeria. Zulli and Zulli describe these practices as "imitation publics," where global participation is made possible through replication and variation [5]. In this sense, TikTok has become a stage for global cultural flows in ways that Instagram has not.

This global stage is also economic. TikTok is not merely entertainment but a livelihood infrastructure for many creators. Through partnerships, live-streaming gifts, and brand sponsorships, TikTok sustains new forms of digital labor. For small creators, it provides opportunities that Instagram often does not, because TikTok's algorithm can propel previously unknown individuals to viral visibility overnight. However, this very reliance reveals precarity: when access is cut off, creators lose not only a stage but their primary source of income. Scholars have described these creators as part of the "creative class" engaged in digital labor [18], whose livelihoods depend on cultural production within volatile platform economies. TikTok thus exemplifies both the opportunities and the vulnerabilities of creative labor in the digital era.

3.2. Localization Pressures and the Role of Nationalism

The very features that make TikTok global also make it vulnerable to nationalist intervention. Governments frame TikTok as a danger in several ways. First, there are data security concerns: national leaders fear that user data could be exploited by foreign powers, making TikTok a vector for surveillance [16]. Second, algorithmic manipulation is seen as a threat to democratic discourse. Scholars like Gillespie argue that recommendation systems shape what users see, and states worry about foreign influence over information flows [13]. Third, TikTok represents a challenge to information sovereignty. As a mediascape, it bypasses traditional gatekeepers, raising anxieties about losing control over national narratives.

These concerns are not theoretical but embedded in political decisions. In June 2020, India banned TikTok after border clashes with China, citing national security. Over 200 million users and countless creators were cut off overnight [10]. The move was framed as a defense of sovereignty: removing a foreign-controlled platform was equated with protecting the nation.

The same logic resurfaced in the United States. Under the Protecting Americans from Foreign Adversary Controlled Applications Act (PAFACA), ByteDance was ordered to divest TikTok's U.S. operations or face shutdown. On January 18, 2025, TikTok was briefly inaccessible in the U.S. before enforcement was delayed [19][20]. Although temporary, the shutdown was justified through national security arguments—fears of data harvesting and manipulation by a foreign government. For policymakers, TikTok's status as a global mediascape was precisely what made it risky: it facilitated uncontrolled cultural flows and algorithmic influence that were not anchored in U.S. oversight.

These episodes demonstrate how nationalism functions as an infrastructural response to globalization. Mihelj calls this platform nationalism: platforms are pressured to adapt to national regulatory environments, fragmenting their global form into localized versions [8]. Douyin exemplifies this within China, where patriotic content is algorithmically privileged and dissenting voices marginalized [2][3]. Outside China, bans and shutdowns reflect the same nationalist impulse, justified in the language of security and sovereignty.

3.3. TikTok Between Global Flows and National Borders

Taken together, TikTok illustrates a paradox. It operates as a global mediascape, producing hybrid cultural forms and sustaining new economies of digital labor. At the same time, its globalism is precisely what triggers nationalist anxieties. States perceive the platform as dangerous because it unsettles established frameworks of control: it collects massive amounts of data, operates through opaque algorithms, and circulates cultural content across borders beyond traditional gatekeeping.

This duality reveals why TikTok is more than entertainment. It is simultaneously an engine of globalization and a flashpoint for nationalism. Its global reach fosters new possibilities for identity and livelihood, but its infrastructural dependence on corporate and political governance exposes the fragility of digital belonging. As the following discussion will show, these tensions materialize most vividly in the experiences of TikTok refugees—users and creators displaced by bans and shutdowns, whose stories highlight the precarity of digital identities in a world where cosmopolitan networks are continually fractured by nationalist logics.

The tensions outlined in the main body become tangible in the experiences of TikTok refugees—users and creators displaced when global flows collide with nationalist regulation. Their cases reveal how fragile digital identities and livelihoods are when tied to platforms that operate simultaneously as global mediascapes and national flashpoints.

The 2020 ban in India exemplifies this fragility. Over 200 million users lost access overnight, and creators with millions of followers saw their communities vanish [10]. Kumar documents how many attempted to migrate to Instagram Reels, YouTube Shorts, or domestic apps such as Moj and Chingari, but few achieved comparable visibility. In practice, follower counts did not translate into algorithmic reach, highlighting what Nieborg and Poell call the "platformization of cultural production" [15]. Beyond visibility, the ban also disrupted creators' incomes and community ties. Many reported dramatic losses in sponsorships and live-streaming revenue, while others described the sudden disappearance of TikTok-specific subcultures as a rupture of their digital identities. The India case shows how nationalism transforms a global mediascape into a fragmented set of localized publics, producing digital refugees whose identities and livelihoods collapse with the platform.

A concrete example is Geet, an Indian motivational speaker and educator who once reached millions on TikTok. After the ban, her content became invisible to her Indian followers, despite her

continued presence abroad [21]. She moved to Instagram, but the transition was marked by declining reach and reduced opportunities for monetization [22]. Her story underscores the precarity of digital labor: when access to TikTok was severed, she not only lost income but also the community that anchored her digital identity. Geet's experience illustrates how creators "live" within mediascapes and how nationalism's infrastructural interventions can displace them into exile.

The 2025 U.S. shutdown further confirms this precarity. Under the Protecting Americans from Foreign Adversary Controlled Applications Act, TikTok was briefly inaccessible before enforcement was delayed [19][20]. Although temporary, the disruption triggered panic among creators, who rushed to redirect audiences to other platforms. The event revealed the instability of digital belonging: even short interruptions fracture networks of visibility and community. Girard is right to argue that consumer identities remain constrained by national logics—TikTok's global reach offered no protection against nationalist sovereignty claims [16].

Together, these cases illustrate the precarious condition of digital cosmopolitanism. TikTok functions as a mediascape [1], but one constantly fractured by banal nationalism [7] and platform nationalism [8]. Refugees embody this paradox: they are not simply migrants between apps but displaced subjects whose identities, livelihoods, and communities are contingent on infrastructures beyond their control. Their stories show that the promise of globalization is always shadowed by the risk of exile.

4. Conclusion

This paper has examined how short-video platforms like TikTok embody the paradoxical relationship between globalization and nationalism. As a global mediascape, TikTok fosters unprecedented cultural flows, enabling memes, sounds, and performances to travel across borders with remarkable speed. Unlike Instagram, which remains tied to social networks, TikTok's algorithmic content graph has allowed it to become both a creative stage and a livelihood infrastructure. Yet these very features make TikTok a focal point of nationalist anxieties: its data collection practices, algorithmic opacity, and transnational reach are framed as threats to sovereignty and security.

The analysis shows that nationalism operates as more than discourse; it is infrastructural. In China, Douyin demonstrates how platform design can privilege patriotic content and marginalize dissent [2][3]. In India and the United States, bans and shutdowns justified through security narratives reveal how states fragment global platforms into localized versions [10][19][20]. These interventions illustrate what Mihelj terms platform nationalism—the reassertion of national boundaries through digital infrastructures [8]. TikTok is therefore not a singular global arena but a set of contested nationalized spaces.

The discussion of TikTok refugees further highlights the human consequences of this fragmentation. The India ban of 2020 and the U.S. shutdown of 2025 produced waves of digital displacement, forcing creators to migrate and adapt to unfamiliar platforms. Their experiences underscore the precarity of digital identity and labor: visibility, income, and community can vanish overnight when platforms are politicized. Cases such as Geet, an Indian creator whose digital livelihood was disrupted by the ban, make visible how cosmopolitan belonging is always vulnerable to nationalist interventions [21][22].

This study contributes to ongoing debates in media and communication by linking globalization theory, platform nationalism, and digital labor research. It shows that short-video platforms are neither borderless spaces of creativity nor mere tools of state control, but hybrid terrains where cosmopolitan flows and nationalist logics coexist and collide. Future research might extend this analysis by examining how emerging regulations around artificial intelligence and algorithmic transparency further reshape global digital publics [17].

Ultimately, the story of TikTok demonstrates that the promise of digital globalization is inseparable from the risk of exile. Global mediascapes open possibilities for connection, but nationalism ensures that these connections remain precarious.

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